POINT OF CHANGE / OPERATIONS

What Your Dashboard Learns Too Late

A useful warning reaches somebody who can still change the outcome.



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The delivery report goes red on Wednesday. A restaurant opening is a week away and the fixtures aren't on site. The supplier had told purchasing on Monday that a driver substitution still needed approval. On Tuesday, the job could have approved it or reserved a compatible alternative. By the time the owner sees a missed milestone, the practical choices are paying for a rush or changing the opening plan.

The report is accurate. The decision arrived two days late.

A leading indicator is a change you can observe before the outcome and early enough to act. Start with the decision you want to preserve. Identify the event that should trigger it, the time left to act, and the person who can respond. Test whether the warning changes decisions on real jobs.

When is a warning early enough to matter?

An alert matters when the remaining time exceeds the time someone needs to act. Locate the decision deadline before choosing the status you want on the dashboard. A useful warning also says what changed and where the information came from.

You realize a package is heading to your old address. If the shipment is eligible and still in transit, UPS describes a service that lets the shipper request a change to where it goes. Once it has arrived, the problem becomes one of recovery. The information can be identical in both cases. The choices are different. In a project, ask when purchasing can still reserve the alternate driver, when dispatch can still move the crew and when the operator needs to hear about a change. A warning that misses those deadlines will help with the explanation and arrive too late for the decision. UPS Delivery Intercept

Which signals would have helped the restaurant project?

Work backward from the last time you could reserve a viable alternative or change the installation plan. Use evidence you can get before then. Send the signal to the employee who can act, and name the person who decides if there's a trade-off in cost or scope.

What you can observe	When it helps	Who can act
Supplier says a required substitution is pending.	Before the deadline to reserve a compatible alternative.	Purchasing brings the options to the technical lead.
The technical lead approves an option and the carrier has yet to confirm collection.	Before the installer needs to commit labor.	Dispatch confirms collection or asks for a revised crew plan.
The site misses its delivery date.	When recovery or customer communication is needed.	The PM owns the revised plan and informs the operator.

A dashboard can show all three. Only the first two preserve choices before the missed date. Label the deadline and the required response. “Vendor risk” is easy to skim. “Approve compatible driver by Tuesday noon to keep Thursday installation” tells someone what to do with it.

What should the weekly exception review record?

Use one line per issue with a decision still open. Capture the signal, when it was observed, the decision deadline, who can act, and what happened. Check missed warnings and false alarms as well as warnings that got a useful response.

Review recent jobs to see whether the signal was available and whether it gave enough time. If suppliers frequently miss a confirmation deadline and most deliveries still arrive, test a narrower alert for items on the critical path. If a useful warning got ignored, ask whether it went to a person without authority or landed in a meeting after the deadline.

On the restaurant job, an exception could read “Substitute driver pending. Alternate stock held until Tuesday at noon. Technical lead to decide by 10 a.m. Purchasing to release the hold or book the alternate.” Ask purchasing to record the time of the decision and the effect on installation. In the next review, you can see whether the signal preserved a choice, arrived after the cutoff or sent someone to chase a decision that had already been made.

Three checks before adding another alert.

- Name the decision it keeps open.
- Show when someone needs to act and who can do it.
- Review the actual response and what changed for the job.

On Monday, a purchasing employee sees the substitution request and knows there’s a choice to make by noon Tuesday. By Wednesday, the owner can see how the job was protected, with a date the operator can still use.

Frequently asked questions

Is a leading indicator the same as a forecast?

A forecast estimates what may happen. A leading indicator is a specific condition you can observe ahead of the outcome and use to decide what to do next.

How early should a warning appear?

Allow enough time for the employee to verify the signal and act. Work backward from the real decision deadline, including the time other people need to respond.

What if alerts keep getting ignored?

Check how often they lead to an action, whether they reach the right person, and whether the message shows a deadline. Narrow or remove alerts that rarely help someone make a decision.

The restaurant scenario is illustrative. The shipping example draws on UPS's published guidance.